in and out of NATO in relation to the American empire. But the fact that these are only regional conflicts displays the limited character of China's and Russia's nationalism, played out in direct relation to the global role of the US empire.

In fact, the most salient conflicts in the world today are class conflicts within states, including the US, rather than conflicts between them. At both Durban and Fortaleza, 'BRICS-from-below' meetings of civil society groups stressed the extent to which the dominant classes and governments of each of the BRICS members were themselves committed to neoliberal policies, often brutally administered in their own countries.[18] They were in this respect at one with the recent L20 trade union statement, made at the Australian G20 meetings, which in criticising 'austerity policies and structural "reforms" that reduce wages and workers' protection' saw the BRICS as no model for an alternative. Indeed, the L20 noted that 'if in emerging Asian economies income distribution had not worsened over the past 20 years, the region's rapid growth would have lifted an extra 240 million people out of poverty.'[19]

This brings us back to one of the central dilemmas of Marxism today, namely the divorce between theory and practice. The working class political institutions that fostered the socialist idea in the 20th century proved unsuitable for realising it. Whether there can be a radical redefinition of socialist politics and labour organisations in the context of new working class struggles is now on the agenda as never before. This is especially so in light of the dangers posed by reactionary nationalisms in Russia and India today, on the one hand, and the promise offered by the strike waves in China, the mass protests in Brazil, and the sponsorship of a new socialist party by the metalworkers' leadership of South Africa's largest trade union. In this sense we are back to 1917, and the hope revolutionaries then entertained about the international reverberations of a break with capitalism in any one country. Even while the unmaking of global capitalism may not necessarily be initiated by radical forces in the heart of empire, the continuing central role of the American state in global capitalism only highlights the great importance today of struggles oriented to bringing about a major shift in the balance of class forces inside the US itself.

## Notes

1. Quoted by Colin Leys, 'The British Ruling Class', *Socialist Register 2014*, p 132. Engels did not see such a war as inevitable, nor as necessary for working class victory. Indeed, in subsequent writings in the years up to his death in 1895 Engels was rather surprisingly unconcerned with the theoretical and political problems raised by the connections between the growing tendencies to the export of capital and the rival militarisms and the scramble for colonies, problems which, 'almost as soon as his ashes had been scattered, forced themselves on the international left in the form of the great debate on imperialism'. See Eric Hobsbawm (2011) *How to Change the*